

ARGENTINA, CHILE, AND URUGUAY



THE SOUTHERN PART of South America is occupied by three countries: Argentina, Chile, and Uruguay. Lying between the Pacific and Atlantic Oceans, South America's southernmost point, Cape Horn, lies only about 1,000 km (600 miles) from the northern tip of Antarctica. Once part of the Spanish Empire, all three countries still show strong European influences. Their vast mineral resources have resulted in some prosperity, but all have agricultural economies and have suffered under a series of unstable governments.

Physical features

Dominating the west of the region, the Andes Mountains form a rugged frontier between Chile and Argentina. The hot, humid land of the Gran Chaco covers the northeast, turning to rolling grassland, known as pampas, in the centre. South of this and the arid plateau of Patagonia, lie the windy islands of Tierra del Fuego.



Andes

Forming a barrier between Chile and its eastern neighbours, Bolivia and Argentina, the vast Andes mountain chain stretches for about 8,000 km (5,000 miles). Nearly half of its mighty snow-capped peaks lie along Chile's long eastern border with Argentina, including Mount Aconcagua, an extinct volcano, which, at 6,960 m (22,835 ft), is the highest peak in South America.



Atacama Desert

The hot Atacama Desert is one of the world's driest places. It covers the northern 965 km (600 miles) of Chile's long coastal strip, and receives less than 13 mm ($\frac{1}{2}$ in) of rain in a year. By contrast, the Patagonian Desert, in the far south of Argentina, near Antarctica, is a vast, icy-cold expanse of windswept rocks.



Pampas

Also known as the Entre Rios, the natural grasslands of the pampas cover about 20 per cent of Argentina and extend north into Uruguay, where three-quarters of the land is rich pasture. Much of the vast pampas has hot summers, warm winters, plenty of rain, and deep, fertile soil, making the area ideal for growing crops and for raising cattle and sheep.



Mestizos

More than three-quarters of the people in this region descend from Europeans, most of whom moved from Spain or Italy in the 20th century. Many of the Europeans intermarried with Native Americans, giving rise to *mestizos*, people of mixed ancestry. Like their ancestors, most people are Roman Catholics and are close to their extended families. Many of them run successful businesses.

Man and child at an Easter festival

21°C
(70°F)



9°C
(48°F)

762 mm
(30 in)

Regional climate

Chile's long, narrow shape gives it an extremely varied climate. Desert and mountains in the north give way to fertile valleys, with hot, dry summers and mild, moist winters. Argentina's southern Andean peaks and Patagonian glaciers have year-round snow; the north is hotter and wetter. Uruguay is mild and pleasant.